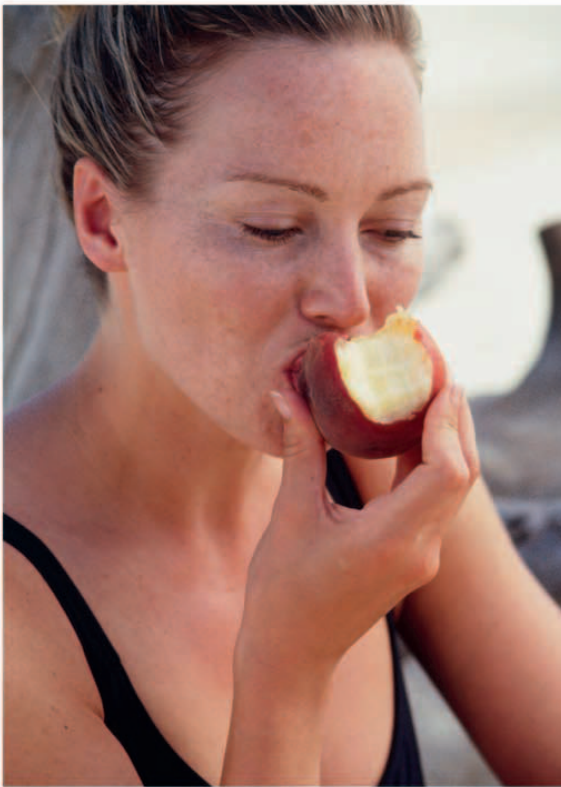


Diet's important, too

As we've seen, calories are units of energy that we get from the food—the carbohydrates, fats, and protein—we eat (see p.98). We take carbs in the form of sugars and complex carbs (bread, grains, beans, vegetables). Fat is usually sourced from oils, butter, meat, and cheese, but there are also high levels of fat in many junk foods, cakes, and cookies. Protein is supplied by meat, poultry, fish, eggs, cheese, and by some beans and grains, but some of these protein sources also have high levels of fat, so you need to choose carefully.

As a general rule, most people need to take in *less* fat—particularly processed fats found in junk and processed foods—and *less* sugar, caffeine, and alcohol. And it would do most of us good to have *more* complex carbs, fiber (from fruit and vegetables), and water.



It's now recommended that one-third of your daily food should consist of fruit and vegetables. So there's truth in the old adage “an apple a day keeps the doctor away.”

>> boost the burn eating tips

- **Eat protein.** Your BMR (see p.98) rises after you eat because it takes energy to eat, digest, and metabolize your food. This is called “thermic effect.” The thermic effect varies according to the type of food you eat. Proteins raise your BMR 30 percent, carbohydrates raise it 6 percent, while fats only raise it 4 percent. Clearly, proteins win hands down!
- **Eat hot, spicy foods.** Foods containing chile, horseradish, and mustard can also have a significant thermic effect, so eating those can raise your BMR.
- **Eat foods that contain iodine.** A diet that's low in iodine reduces your thyroid function, which slows your metabolism. The RDA (recommended daily allowance) is 150mcg. Foods that are richest in iodine are fish and shellfish, but if you happen to be allergic to these, consider taking a supplement. However, too much iodine is also bad for you, so only take a supplement on the advice of a professional practitioner.
- **Eat breakfast.** Your BMR is highest in the morning and tails off gradually through the day, so take advantage of this daily peak. An American study showed that eating a proper meal at the start of the day boosted BMR by 10 percent and that people who skipped breakfast or lunch had a lower BMR than those who didn't.
- **Don't go on a crash diet.** If you eat too little, your metabolism slows so your body can conserve the energy it's got. Crash dieting can reduce your BMR as much as 15 percent. Crash dieting also means you lose lean muscle tissue which, in turn, reduces your BMR.